AI Solutions for Omdurman National Bank

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Executive summary

AInovin can offer Omdurman National Bank (ONB) a three-wave AI programme, starting with a Sudanese-Arabic service agent and a staff knowledge assistant that need no access to customer accounts.

- **Why now:** since the war, Sudan's payments run through mobile apps, and app outages and fraud warnings are frequent. ONB is also rebuilding foreign correspondent banks, which raises the bar on compliance.
- **What we offer:** ten use cases in three waves: service and knowledge first, then trade-finance and compliance automation, then fraud, credit and onboarding models.
- **Where to start:** an 8-week pilot, "ONB Assist": a WhatsApp and voice agent for customers plus a policy assistant for staff.
- **Main constraint:** since 3 July 2026 the Central Bank of Sudan (CBOS) must approve any bank's technical relationship or data link with a provider. The pilot is scoped to need as little of that as possible.

ONB today

ONB already has the digital rails (app, internet banking, payments); what it lacks is the intelligence layer on top: service, compliance and risk.

Area	What we found
Profile	Sharia-compliant public shareholding bank, founded 1993; banking, investment and foreign trade (onb-sd.com)
Products	Corporate: current accounts, letters of credit and guarantee, local and foreign transfers. Retail: current, savings and investment deposits. Project finance: roads, bridges, agriculture, livestock (Zawya)
Digital channels	O-Cash mobile app, Banki-net internet banking, ATMs, POS, SMS, customs-duty and fee payments (onb-sd.com, Zawya)

Area	What we found
O-Cash app	Transfers by account, phone number, other bank and QR; bill payment; e-wallet; exchange rates (store listing). Store listings name outside publishers: to confirm who builds it
Correspondent banks	Feb 2026: GM Abdel Moneim Mohamed al-Tayeb said ONB started setting up three correspondent banks in one country, with more within two months (Sudan Tribune)
Development finance	Multi-sector financing package for Sennar state: agriculture, renewable energy, roads (Actum Sudan)
Recognition	Named best bank in Sudan by The Banker in 2015 (Leading Edge)
Ownership	A 2022 C4ADS report said the army held about 86% of shares through affiliated charities (Al Jazeera)

The correspondent-bank push matters most for us: foreign banks will check ONB's AML, KYC and trade-finance controls closely, and AI can make those faster and better documented.

What Sudan's situation means for ONB

Mobile apps replaced cash during the war, so app reliability, fraud control and customer support are now a Sudanese bank's frontline.

- **Apps are the lifeline.** Bankak, Fawry and O-Cash carry daily payments after looting and cash shortages (OkayAfrica). War losses to banks exceed $20 billion, and bad loans are above 6% (Sudan Tribune).
- **Outages freeze markets.** A Bankak failure halted Eid shopping in May 2026 (Sudan Tribune). On 2 Sept 2026 app failures hit again as the pound fell to 7,000 per dollar on the parallel market (Sudan Tribune).
- **Fraud is rising.** Bank of Khartoum warned customers in April 2025 about phishing links, OTP theft and fake messages (Bank of Khartoum).
- **Rails are being rebuilt.** EBS restored the national switch, ran 100 million account-to-account transfers in Jan–May 2026, and is now a SWIFT service bureau for 26 banks (Sudan Tribune).

- **The regulator is tightening.** Since 3 July 2026, CBOS must give written approval before a bank enters any technical relationship or data link with a provider. It stresses encryption, data governance and access control (Sudan Tribune).
- **Bankak dominates.** Remittances into Sudan rely heavily on Bank of Khartoum's app (Sudan Tribune), so ONB competes for every app user.

The opening for ONB: be the bank that still answers customers clearly when apps fail, and that passes foreign banks' compliance checks.

Solution menu

Ten use cases in three waves; each wave needs more access to bank data, and more CBOS approval, than the one before. Fit: **Strong** = AInovin has built this before, **Good** = within our stack, **Partner** = bring in a specialist.

Wave 1: start now, no customer-account access

Solution	ONB problem	What it does	Access needed	Fit
Customer service agent (WhatsApp, web, phone)	Support swamped during outages and cash shortages	Answers in Sudanese Arabic and English on O-Cash setup, limits, fees, branches, rates; logs complaints; hands off to staff	Approved FAQs, product and fee sheets	Strong
Staff knowledge assistant	CBOS rules change often (limits, currency exchange, approvals)	Staff ask in Arabic; answers cite the exact circular or policy page	CBOS circulars, internal manuals	Strong
O-Cash growth content	Bankak dominates app use and remittances	AI video and social campaigns on O-Cash features and scam awareness	Brand guidelines	Strong

Wave 2: after CBOS approval, read-only bank data

Solution	ONB problem	What it does	Access needed	Fit
Trade-finance document checker	New correspondent banks bring more letters of credit and stricter checks	Reads invoices, bills of lading and certificates; checks them against LC terms; flags discrepancies for an officer	LC files, scanned documents	Good
KYC and AML assistant	Correspondents demand strong due diligence	Builds due-diligence files, screens names against sanctions lists, drafts suspicious-activity reports and correspondent questionnaires	Customer files, licensed screening lists	Good
Reconciliation and reporting	Manual matching of switch, EBS and ledger records	Matches settlement files to the ledger, raises exceptions, drafts routine CBOS reports	Settlement files, ledger exports	Good
App monitoring and outage alerts	App failures destroy trust	Watches O-Cash errors and speed, warns IT early, updates customers by SMS and the agent	App logs, status feed	Good

Wave 3: models on transaction data

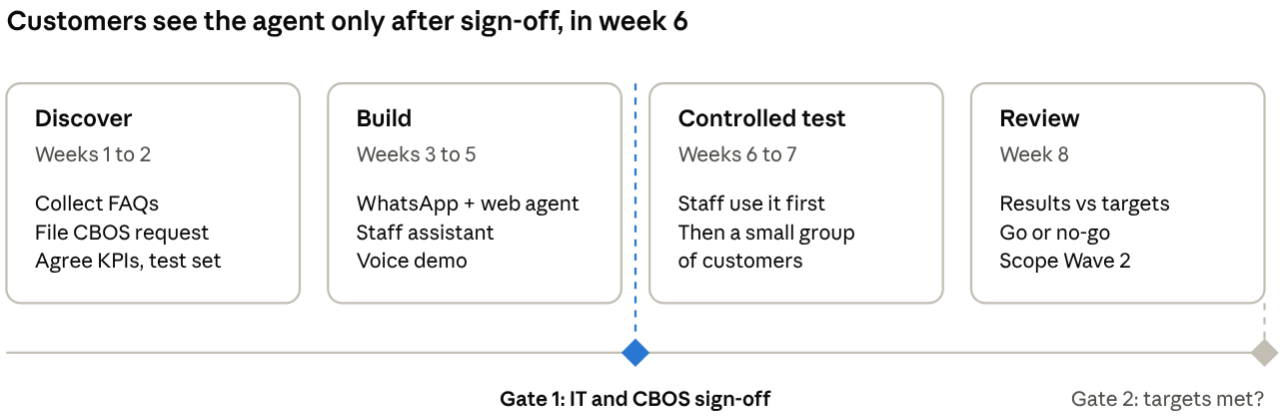
Solution	ONB problem	What it does	Access needed	Fit
Fraud and scam detection	Phishing and account takeover	Scores each transfer for risk (new device, unusual amount, mule patterns) and holds suspicious ones	Live transaction feed and history	Partner

Solution	ONB problem	What it does	Access needed	Fit
Financing and Sharia review assistant	Agriculture and project finance under Islamic contracts	Reads applications and statements, drafts credit memos, checks contracts against the Sharia board's rulings	Financing files, board rulings	Good
Remote account opening (eKYC)	Displaced customers cannot reach branches	ID scan, face match and liveness check inside O-Cash	ID data, CBOS eKYC rules	Partner

Trade-finance checking is a proven category: vendors such as Finastra with Conpend sell it, and research recommends AI plus human review rather than full automation (HBKU).

Recommended start: 8-week "ONB Assist" pilot

Start with the customer agent and the staff assistant: customers see them, value shows within weeks, and neither touches customer accounts.



ONB Assist pilot · 4 phases, 2 gates

Nothing reaches customers until ONB IT and CBOS have signed off; week 8 decides rollout and the first Wave 2 item.

Scope

- WhatsApp and web agent in Sudanese Arabic and English: O-Cash help, fees and limits, branch and service status, exchange rates, complaints logged with a ticket number.
- Phone demo built on AInovin's existing Sudanese Arabic voice agent.

- Staff assistant over CBOS circulars and ONB manuals, answering with the source page.
- Out of scope: balances, transfers and customer records.

How we measure it (targets agreed with ONB in week 1)

- Share of questions answered without a human
- Accuracy on a test set of real customer questions, scored by ONB staff
- Change in call and branch enquiry volume
- Staff time saved per policy lookup

What we need from ONB

- A business sponsor and an IT contact
- Top customer questions and complaints, product and fee sheets
- CBOS circulars and internal manuals
- A WhatsApp Business number and the CBOS filing

Constraints, risks and due diligence

The biggest delays will come from approvals and data rules, not technology; the pilot is shaped around them.

Risk	Why it matters	How we handle it
CBOS prior approval	Any technical link or data exchange with a provider needs written approval since July 2026 (Sudan Tribune)	Pilot touches no customer accounts; ONB files the request in week 1 with our security pack (encryption, access control, data handling)
Customer data confidentiality	CBOS demands strict encryption, data governance and access control	Host in an ONB-approved environment; self-hosted open models for anything touching customer data; cloud AI only for non-customer content
AI provider availability	Some AI services block certain countries	Checked 8 Oct 2026: both OpenAI and Anthropic list Sudan as supported for API access

Risk	Why it matters	How we handle it
Sudanese dialect accuracy	The best published Sudanese speech model still has a 57% word error rate (arXiv)	Text first on WhatsApp; voice with short guided flows and read-back confirmations; consented call audio used to fine-tune
Connectivity and outages	Network blackouts and app failures are common	WhatsApp and SMS fallback, queue-and-retry, automatic status messages
Third-party systems	Core banking and O-Cash may be run by outside vendors	Map their APIs in discovery; Wave 1 needs no integration
Wrong answers	A bank cannot afford invented answers	Answers only from approved sources, with the source shown; hand-off when unsure; no account actions in the pilot
Ownership and sanctions	C4ADS reported majority army ownership; Sudan sanctions listings continue in 2026 (GFSC)	Before signing: formal screening of ONB and its owners against OFAC, UK, EU and UN lists; confirm our cloud and voice vendors' terms allow this client; agree the payment route

We found no sanctions listing for ONB itself in the notices we reviewed, but that is not a legal check; get one before contract.

Questions for the first meeting with ONB

These answers decide the pilot scope, the price and which Wave 2 item comes next.

1. Which core banking system does ONB run, and who builds and hosts O-Cash? Are there APIs?
2. How many customer enquiries come in per month, by channel (calls, WhatsApp, Facebook, branches)? What are the top 20 questions and complaints?
3. Who at ONB owns CBOS approvals, and what did past vendor approvals require?
4. Where must data and AI models be hosted: on-premise, in Sudan, or in an approved cloud?
5. How many letters of credit and guarantees does ONB handle per month, and how many staff check the documents?

6. Which AML and sanctions-screening system is in place, and what are the new correspondent banks asking for?
7. How many fraud cases hit O-Cash per month, and how are they caught today?
8. Which Islamic financing products carry the most volume, and how long does an approval take?
9. Where are the IT and operations teams based now, and how reliable is their connectivity?
10. Who sponsors the pilot, and what result would make it a success for them?

Sources

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